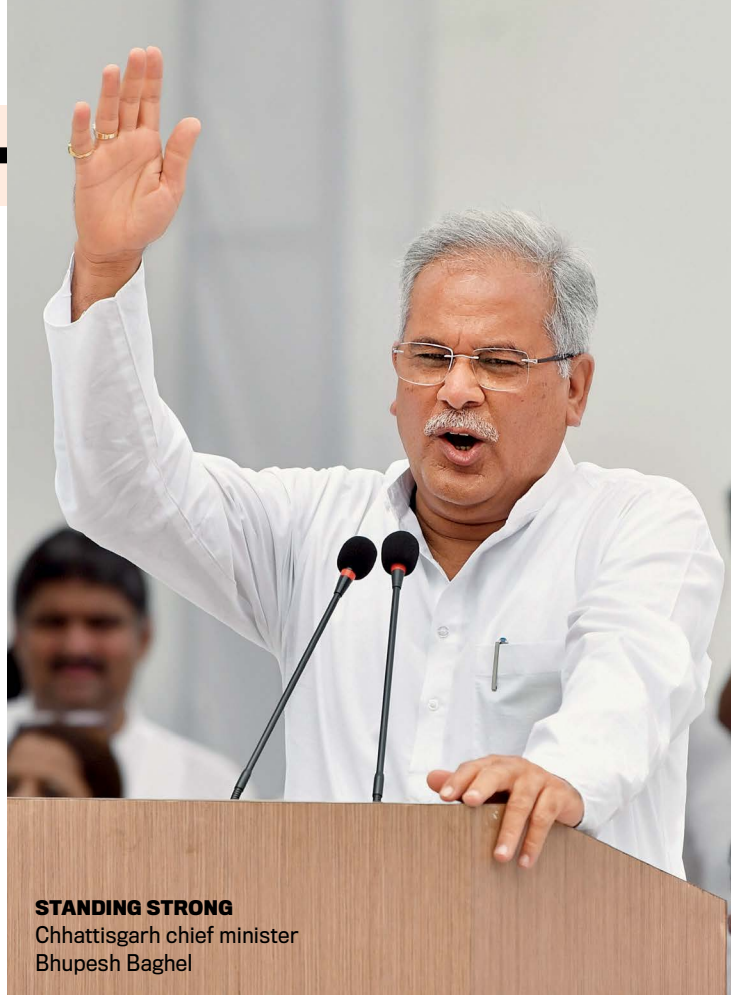
ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023
CHHATTISGARH

SECURE IN HIS CITADEL

BAGHEL IS RELYING ON HIS PRO-RURAL SCHEMES AND THE CONGRESS'S TRADITIONAL TRIBAL SUPPORT BASE TO HELP HIM WIN A SECOND TERM

By **RAHUL NORONHA**



STANDING STRONG
Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel

ANI

"***Kaka abhi zinda hai*** (Your uncle is still alive)," is an oft-repeated assurance from Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel at his *'bhent-mulakat'* outreach programme across the state's 90 assembly segments, which began in May last year. Now, as the 62-year-old 'avuncular' leader barnstorms down the state, he wants an assurance from the electorate in return—that they will give his Congress regime another five years in power. Baghel, as the then Pradesh Congress Committee president, had led the Congress to an unprecedented win in 2018, winning 68 of the 90 seats in Chhattisgarh. The party has only grown stronger since then, winning all five byelections. Its present tally in the state assembly stands at 71, even as that of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—which ruled the state for three consecutive terms under former chief minister Raman Singh—has dropped from 15 to 14 in the past five years.

As Baghel sets his eyes on further denting the BJP's prospects in Chhattisgarh, he is pinning his hopes on a slew of farmer-friendly schemes that have successfully covered swathes of the state's predominantly rural population. This pro-agriculture push began with farm loan waivers right after Baghel, who belongs to the agricultural Kurmi community, came to power in 2018. He also announced the Rajiv Gandhi Kisan Nyay Yojana, promising to buy paddy, the state's staple crop, at Rs 2,500 per quintal from

THE CM'S REPORT CARD

STRENGTHS

- Pro-farmer schemes for the rural/ OBC population in central Chhattisgarh
- Traditional tribal support base in north and south belts
- Invoking Chhattisgarhi pride and 'soft Hindutva' to counter the BJP's Hindutva agenda

CHALLENGES

- Perceptible anti-incumbency against some Congress MLAs
- Lingering bitterness among the party's top leadership; corruption charges
- A possible backlash in urban areas, where voters feel ignored